

According to Mehta, Skid is free to download, and can be used to develop a number of applications. But what was the reason for going with the Ruby on Rails framework? "We were looking for something that would be easy to develop applications on. Another consideration was to work in a language in which it would be easier for others to build modules and functionalities as well," says Mehta. Apart from this, it is based on common Web standards like HTML and HTTP. Web standards do not fade away with time, as do other technologies, which go through their different life cycles. Part of this work philosophy comes from Mehta's stint with Siemens—a German company where he learnt that every technology should ideally be designed to be 'future-proof'.

However, while designing modules for Skid, one of the things to be kept in mind is the nature of the disorder, its

level and the age of the child, he adds.

The future

Mehta feels the future of this communication system lies in adapting and moving it onto mobile phones, mainly because mobiles offer a variety of ways to input data and interact with the device. He elaborates: "Modern smartphones have touchscreens, physical keypads, camera input, GPS, accelerometers which sense change in movement and orientation, voice recognition, and a whole lot of features that can be used to input data into the system and get the desired results."

Some of the recent versions, like the iPhone 4, come with a gyroscope, which can accurately measure a user's motion and direction changes in 3-D space. Such features can be exploited to build apps that would further aid the learning of children with special needs.

Mehta also thinks that in order for this communication platform to gain

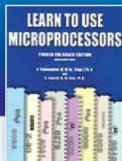
more recognition and acceptance, it needs to be further refined on a commercial scale, in consultation with specialists like psychologists, neurologists and top-notch medical and engineering colleges.

Certainly, if adopted on a large scale, Arpit's Wheel has the potential to change the lives of millions of disabled children. A celebrated physicist like Stephen Hawking, who himself suffers from a type of neurological disorder, can afford to have a sophisticated program that helps him talk. But people with limited means can benefit immensely from inexpensive innovations like Arpit's Wheel, which is indeed a commendable step forward to help disabled children lead a normal life. ●

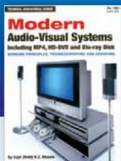
The author is a technology enthusiast with an interest in mobile phones, gaming and free software. He also loves dabbling with his video camera occasionally

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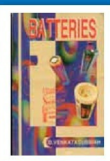
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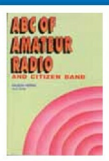
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